

The AI Tool Truth Test

A 12-point scorecard to audit any AI tool before you pay — built from 14 months of real tests.

How to use this: Run any AI tool through these 12 tests in your first 14-day trial. Score each 0–5. A tool that scores under 36 is leaking your time and money — cut it before the refund window closes. Most "best AI tool" lists skip 9 of these tests. That's why most reviews don't convert into honest decisions.

Tool Under Test

TOOL NAME	PLAN / PRICE
TRIAL LENGTH	TEST START DATE
REFUND WINDOW ENDS	USE CASE TESTED

The 12-Point Test

#	Test	How to score it (0–5)	Score
1	Sycophancy check <i>The one that kills most tools fast.</i>	Give it a bad idea. Score 5 if it pushes back with reasons. Score 0 if it praises ("Great question!") before answering.	/ 5
2	Source honesty	Ask for a statistic with a date. Score 5 if it cites a real, verifiable source. Score 0 if it invents one or refuses.	/ 5
3	Day-11 friction	On day 11 of trial, log every friction point. Score 5 if friction is zero. Score 0 if you've already opened a competitor.	/ 5
4	Output editing time	Time how long to edit one output to publish-ready. Score 5 if under 5 min. Score 0 if you rewrite from scratch.	/ 5
5	Voice drift	Run the same prompt on day 1 and day 7. Score 5 if voice stays consistent. Score 0 if it sounds like 3 different tools.	/ 5
6	Pricing transparency	Read the pricing page. Score 5 if every limit is named upfront. Score 0 if you need a sales call to know real cost.	/ 5
7	Export freedom	Try to export your data. Score 5 if 1 click to standard format. Score 0 if locked or charged extra.	/ 5

#	Test	How to score it (0–5)	Score
8	Support reality	Email support a real question. Score 5 if human reply under 24h. Score 0 if bot loop or never.	/ 5
9	Cancel friction	Find the cancel button. Score 5 if 2 clicks max. Score 0 if hidden, requires email, or "let us help you stay."	/ 5
10	Week-3 abandonment risk	By week 3 of paid use — do you still open it daily? Score 5 yes. Score 0 if you forgot it exists.	/ 5
11	Refund test	Read refund policy day 1. Score 5 if clear, generous, automatic. Score 0 if "no refunds" or 7 hoops.	/ 5
12	Replaceability	Could ChatGPT/Claude do 80% of this for \$20? Score 5 if NO (real moat). Score 0 if obviously YES.	/ 5

VERDICT

36+ = keep · 24–35 = re-evaluate at next billing · under 24 = cancel before refund window closes

Total score:

/ 60

What 14 months of running this test taught me: tools that score under 36 almost never get better. The friction you see in week 1 compounds, not fades. The "I'll learn it more" excuse is the most expensive sentence in affiliate marketing. Cancel before the refund window closes. Use the saved \$30–\$200/month to test the next 2 tools properly.

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